

A Game of Connection

The Chinese New Year holiday this year was quite unusual for me. This is mainly because I chose to take the night shift while my colleagues were enjoying time off with their family and friends. With only two days off before work began, I decided to visit my grandparents and aunt. I enjoyed two relaxing days at their home, and during that time, I stumbled upon something unexpected that sparked my interest.

It all started with a game of Chinese chess against my grandpa. He had been trying to teach me how to play ever since I was a child, but I had never truly felt motivated to learn it seriously. This time, however, was different. My original intention was simply to keep my grandpa company, but once the game began, I found myself genuinely enjoying it—especially when I managed to seize small advantages from his occasional slips. Chinese chess is undeniably complex, but it was precisely that complexity that gave rise to a deep sense of achievement and fun.

I'm not sure when I will next have the chance to sit across the chessboard from my grandpa again, but on my way back to Taipei, I downloaded a teaching app to continue learning on my own. Although I honestly don't have much free time to refine my skills, I hope to at least nurture it as a small hobby—and, more importantly, as a meaningful connection between my grandpa and me.

PART A: VOCABULARY (15 Words)

Study the following vocabulary words from the text. Pay attention to how each word is used in context.

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	stumble upon (phr. v.)	to find or discover something by chance, without planning. <i>"I stumbled upon something unexpected that sparked my interest."</i>
2	spark (v.)	to cause something to start or ignite, especially interest or enthusiasm. <i>"Something unexpected that sparked my interest."</i>
3	motivated (adj.)	having a reason or desire to do something; driven. <i>"I had never truly felt motivated to learn it seriously."</i>
4	intention (n.)	a plan or purpose behind an action. <i>"My original intention was simply to keep my grandpa company."</i>
5	accompany (v.)	to go somewhere with someone as a companion. <i>"My initial aim in starting the game was simply to accompany my grandpa."</i>
6	genuinely (adv.)	in a sincere and real way; truly. <i>"I found myself genuinely enjoying it."</i>
7	seize (v.)	to take hold of something quickly and eagerly. <i>"I managed to seize small advantages from his occasional slips."</i>
8	slip (n.)	a small mistake or error, often unintentional. <i>"I managed to seize small advantages from his occasional slips."</i>
9	complicated (adj.)	consisting of many parts or aspects; not easy to understand. <i>"Chinese chess is undeniably complex."</i>
10	occasional (adj.)	happening from time to time; not frequent or regular. <i>"I managed to seize small advantages from his occasional slips."</i>
11	give rise to (phr. v.)	to cause or produce something. <i>"That complexity gave rise to a deep sense of achievement and fun."</i>
12	achievement (n.)	something accomplished through effort or skill. <i>"A deep sense of achievement and fun."</i>

13	chessboard (n.)	the board on which chess is played. <i>"When I will next have the chance to sit across the chessboard from my grandpa."</i>
14	refine (v.)	to improve something by making small changes. <i>"I honestly don't have much free time to refine my skills."</i>
15	meaningful (adj.)	having purpose, significance, or value. <i>"A meaningful connection between my grandpa and me."</i>

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

- While cleaning the attic, she _____ an old photo album from the 1950s.
 - refined
 - stumbled upon
 - accompanied
 - seized
- The exciting trailer _____ my curiosity about the new movie.
 - accompanied
 - refined
 - sparked
 - slipped
- She wasn't _____ enough to wake up early for morning jogs.
 - meaningful
 - undeniably
 - genuine
 - motivated
- His _____ was to apologize, but the conversation went in a different direction.
 - achievement
 - intention
 - slip
 - chessboard

5. The detective _____ the opportunity to question the suspect before the lawyer arrived.

- a) stumbled upon
- b) accompanied
- c) refined
- d) seized

6. She felt _____ happy when she received the surprise gift from her old friend.

- a) occasionally
- b) complicatedly
- c) genuinely
- d) meaningfully

7. The new policy _____ a heated debate among the employees.

- a) refined
- b) gave rise to
- c) accompanied
- d) sparked

8. His _____ of the tongue revealed the surprise party they had been planning.

- a) intention
- b) slip
- c) achievement
- d) spark

9. The author spent months _____ the manuscript before submitting it to the publisher.

- a) seizing
- b) accompanying
- c) refining
- d) stumbling upon

10. Volunteering at the shelter was a _____ experience that changed her perspective.

- a) motivated
- b) meaningful
- c) complicated
- d) occasional

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

stumble upon spark seize achievement slip

1. Winning the national science competition was her greatest _____ in high school.
2. The comedian's _____ on stage made everyone laugh even harder.
3. You never know what treasures you might _____ at a flea market.
4. A single conversation can _____ a lifelong friendship.
5. When opportunity knocks, you should _____ it without hesitation.

motivated intention genuinely refine meaningful

6. She _____ cared about every student in her class.
7. His _____ was to help, but his words came across as criticism.
8. Students who are _____ tend to perform better on exams.
9. You can _____ your writing by reading it aloud and making small changes.
10. They shared a _____ look that said more than words ever could.

PART B: GRAMMAR (5 Patterns)

Study the following grammar structures from the text.

Pattern 1: "Ever since" for duration from past to present

Form: Subject + has/have + past participle + ever since + past time point

Use: To express that something started in the past and continues to the present.

Example from text: *"He had been trying to teach me how to play ever since I was a child."*

More examples:

- She has loved painting ever since she was a little girl.
- They have been best friends ever since they met in college.
- I have been interested in cooking ever since I watched that TV show.

Pattern 2: "Find + oneself + gerund" for unexpected realization

Form: Subject + find/found + oneself + verb-ing

Use: To describe becoming aware of doing something without planning or expecting it.

Example from text: *"I found myself genuinely enjoying it."*

More examples:

- After moving abroad, she found herself missing her hometown.
- He found himself smiling at the old photographs.
- I often find myself thinking about that conversation.

Pattern 3: "Especially when" to highlight a specific situation

Form: Main clause + especially when + subject + verb

Use: To single out a particular situation where the main idea applies most strongly.

Example from text: *"I found myself genuinely enjoying it—especially when I managed to seize small advantages from his occasional slips."*

More examples:

- Cooking is relaxing, especially when I have the whole kitchen to myself.
- Public speaking can be nerve-wracking, especially when the audience is large.
- I love autumn, especially when the leaves start changing color.

Pattern 4: "I'm not sure when/whether + clause" (Embedded question)

Form: Subject + be + not sure + question word + subject + verb (statement order)

Use: To express uncertainty. Note that the embedded clause uses statement word order, not question order.

Example from text: *"I'm not sure when I will next have the chance to sit across the chessboard from my grandpa."*

More examples:

- I'm not sure where she went after the meeting.
- He isn't sure whether he should accept the offer.
- We're not sure how long the project will take.

Pattern 5: "More importantly" as a sentence connector

Form: ... and, more importantly, + clause

Use: To add a second point that carries greater significance than the first.

Example from text: *"I hope to nurture it as a small hobby—and, more importantly, as a meaningful connection between my grandpa and me."*

More examples:

- The project was completed on time and, more importantly, within budget.
- She is talented and, more importantly, willing to work hard.
- The trip was fun and, more importantly, it brought the family closer together.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. She has been passionate about music ever since she _____ her first concert.
 - a) attends
 - b) attended
 - c) has attended
 - d) attending
2. After reading for an hour, I found _____ falling asleep on the couch.
 - a) me
 - b) myself
 - c) mine
 - d) I

3. Traveling is exciting, especially _____ you visit a country for the first time.
- a) that
 - b) when
 - c) which
 - d) so
4. I'm not sure _____ the store closes on Sundays.
- a) what time does
 - b) what time
 - c) does what time
 - d) what does time
5. The internship gave her experience and, more _____, professional connections.
- a) important
 - b) importance
 - c) importantly
 - d) importing
6. They have lived in this neighborhood ever since they _____ married.
- a) get
 - b) got
 - c) have gotten
 - d) getting
7. He found _____ agreeing with someone he used to disagree with.
- a) him
 - b) his
 - c) he
 - d) himself
8. I enjoy reading, especially when the story _____ me think about my own life.
- a) make
 - b) makes
 - c) making
 - d) made
9. She isn't sure _____ she left her keys.
- a) where did
 - b) where
 - c) did where
 - d) where does
10. The new policy saves money and, more importantly, _____ employee satisfaction.

- a) improve
- b) improves
- c) improving
- d) improved

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern indicated in parentheses.

Ever since for duration

1. He started collecting stamps when he was ten. He still collects them now. (ever since...)

2. I began loving Japanese food after my trip to Tokyo. (ever since...)

Find oneself + gerund

3. She didn't plan to cry, but she cried during the movie. (She found...)

4. Without realizing it, he was spending hours on the game. (He found...)

Especially when

5. I like working from home. It's best on rainy days. (I like working from home, especially...)

6. Learning a language is hard. It's hardest when you have no one to practice with. (Learning a language is hard, especially...)

Embedded question (I'm not sure...)

7. When will the results be announced? I don't know. (I'm not sure...)

8. How much does this cost? I have no idea. (I'm not sure...)

More importantly

9. The job pays well. But the most important thing is that it allows flexible hours. (The job pays well and...)

10. He passed the test. The most important thing is that he gained confidence. (He passed the test and...)

PART C: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions based on the text.

Tier 1: Literal Understanding

1. Why was the author's Chinese New Year unusual this year?
2. What did the author do during the two days off before work?
3. What did the author download on the way back to Taipei?

Tier 2: Inference & Analysis

4. Why do you think the author's attitude toward Chinese chess changed this time compared to childhood?
5. What does the author mean by calling the chess app "a small connection" between them and their grandpa?
6. How does the complexity of Chinese chess contribute to the author's enjoyment, rather than discourage them?

Tier 3: Critical Thinking

7. The author says Chinese chess is complex, but that the complexity is what makes it fun. Can you think of other activities where difficulty is part of the enjoyment? Why do you think some people are attracted to challenges rather than discouraged by them?
8. Do you think learning Chinese chess through an app can replace the experience of playing with the author's grandpa? Why or why not?

Tier 4: Personal Response

9. Is there a hobby or activity that connects you to a family member? Describe it and explain why it is special to you.
10. Have you ever unexpectedly discovered a new interest? What happened, and did you continue pursuing it?

PART D: CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Discuss the following questions with a partner or in small groups.

Group 1: Family Traditions & Holidays

1. How does your family usually celebrate Chinese New Year (or another major holiday)?
2. Have you ever had to work or study during a holiday? How did that affect your celebration?
3. Is there a tradition you share with a grandparent or older family member that you hope to keep alive? What is it?

Group 2: Hobbies & Unexpected Interests

4. What is a hobby you picked up unexpectedly? How did it start?
5. Do you prefer hobbies that challenge your mind (like chess or puzzles) or ones that relax you (like drawing or cooking)? Why?
6. Have you ever tried to learn something just to spend time with someone else? What happened?

Group 3: Board Games & Strategy

7. What board games or card games are popular in your country or culture?
8. Do you think playing strategy games like chess can improve your thinking skills in daily life? How?
9. Some people prefer playing games on apps, while others prefer playing in person. Which do you prefer, and why?

Group 4: Connections Across Generations

10. What is something valuable you've learned from an older family member?
11. Do you think younger and older generations have enough opportunities to bond with each other today? Why or why not?
12. If you could teach a grandparent or older relative one modern skill (and they could teach you one traditional skill), what would you each teach?

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) stumbled upon 2. c) sparked 3. d) motivated 4. b) intention 5. d) seized 6. c) genuinely 7. b) gave rise to 8. b) slip 9. c) refining 10. b) meaningful

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. achievement 2. slip 3. stumble upon 4. spark 5. seize 6. genuinely 7. intention 8. motivated 9. refine 10. meaningful

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) attended 2. b) myself 3. b) when 4. b) what time 5. c) importantly 6. b) got 7. d) himself 8. b) makes 9. b) where 10. b) improves

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

1. He has been collecting stamps ever since he was ten.
2. I have loved Japanese food ever since my trip to Tokyo.
3. She found herself crying during the movie.
4. He found himself spending hours on the game.
5. I like working from home, especially when it's raining.
6. Learning a language is hard, especially when you have no one to practice with.
7. I'm not sure when the results will be announced.
8. I'm not sure how much this costs.
9. The job pays well and, more importantly, allows flexible hours.
10. He passed the test and, more importantly, gained confidence.

Comprehension Questions (Sample Answers)

1. The author chose to take the night shift while other colleagues were enjoying the holiday with family and friends.
2. The author visited their grandparents and aunt and enjoyed two relaxing days.
3. The author downloaded a Chinese chess teaching app.
4. As a child, the author had no personal interest in learning chess. This time, the author was older and chose to play voluntarily to accompany their grandpa, which made the experience feel different and enjoyable.
5. The app allows the author to continue practicing and improving at chess even when they are far from their grandpa, so it serves as a way to maintain the bond and shared interest they discovered together.
6. The complexity makes it more rewarding when the author manages to gain an advantage, creating a sense of achievement that a simpler game might not provide.

7. It suggests the author is responsible, hardworking, and willing to put duty before personal comfort—qualities also reflected in the original text about working night shifts.

8. Answers will vary. Students may argue that the app is useful for skill-building but cannot replace the warmth and personal interaction of playing face-to-face with a grandparent.

9–10. Answers will vary based on personal experience.